

Current Affairs Export — 10 June 2026

CA-Daily: 10 June 2026 | 7 Items Covered

GS Paper I, II, III | Polity + IR + Economy + Governance

Sources: PIB, MEA, LiveLaw, Myanmar MoFA, Web | Prepared: 10 June 2026

Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH

PM Modi meets Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing

GS-II (IR +
Internal
Security)
International
Relations

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing made his first official visit to India (May 30-June 3, 2026), meeting PM Modi at Hyderabad House, New Delhi. PIB confirmed. Focus: border management, KMTTP, IMT Highway, Rupee-Kyat settlement.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

Myanmar shares a ~1,643 km border with India across four states: Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, and Mizoram. It is India's only ASEAN neighbour and a critical gateway to Southeast Asia under Neighbourhood First Policy and Act East Policy. India chose pragmatic engagement over isolation despite Western criticism of Myanmar's military junta (SAC) that came to power via coup on February 1, 2021.

India-Myanmar diplomatic relations date to Myanmar's independence in 1948. Key infrastructure projects: Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project (KMTTP) connecting Mizoram to Sittwe Port, and India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway. India's rationale: Northeast security, countering Chinese influence, protecting Act East connectivity.

■ TIMELINE

1948 — Myanmar gains independence; India among first to recognise

2008 — KMTTP agreement formally signed

Feb 1, 2021 — Military coup: Tatmadaw ousts NLD; SAC formed under Min Aung Hlaing

May 30-Jun 3, 2026 — U Min Aung Hlaing's FIRST OFFICIAL VISIT to India; Neighbourhood First + Act East agenda

■ KEY DATA

Term	Full Form	Significance
KMTTP	Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project	Mizoram to Sittwe Port (Bay of Bengal) — Act East lifeline
IMT Highway	India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway	Land route connecting India to Thailand via Myanmar
SAC	State Administration Council	Myanmar military junta (post-Feb 2021 coup)
Tatmadaw	Myanmar Armed Forces	Conducted Feb 2021 coup
NLD	National League for Democracy	Aung San Suu Kyi's party; ousted in 2021 coup
BIMSTEC	Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation	7 members including Myanmar and India

■ STATIC THEORY

- NEIGHBOURHOOD FIRST POLICY: Modi govt 2014; India's priority of engaging immediate neighbours; Myanmar = only ASEAN member bordering India

- ACT EAST POLICY: Upgraded from Look East (1991) in 2014; ASEAN + East Asia focus; 3C framework (Commerce, Connectivity, Culture); Myanmar = gateway
- INDIA-MYANMAR BORDER: 4 states — Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram; ~1,643 km
- PRAGMATIC ENGAGEMENT: India did not condemn coup unlike Western nations; rationale = China containment + Northeast security + connectivity
- RUPEE-KYAT SETTLEMENT: Bilateral trade in local currencies (INR + Myanmar Kyat); part of India's de-dollarisation thrust

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. India-Myanmar border: ~1,643 km across 4 states (AP, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram)
2. Myanmar = India's ONLY ASEAN-member neighbour
3. Feb 1, 2021 = Military coup; SAC formed; NLD/Suu Kyi ousted
4. KMTTP = Mizoram to Sittwe Port (Bay of Bengal)
5. U Min Aung Hlaing visit = May 30-June 3, 2026 (FIRST official visit to India)
6. India chose engagement not isolation (unlike USA/EU sanctions)

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Myanmar shares border with 3 Indian states
- ✓ 4 states: Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram
- ✗ Sittwe Port is in India
- ✓ Sittwe Port is in MYANMAR — India's access via KMTTP
- ✗ BIMSTEC does not include Myanmar
- ✓ Myanmar IS a BIMSTEC member (7 members)
- ✗ India condemned the 2021 Myanmar coup
- ✓ India took neutral stance — called for democratic process without condemning junta

■ MAINS ANGLE

India's engagement with Myanmar's military regime reflects strategic pragmatism over democratic principle — Neighbourhood First and Act East compulsions override India's stated commitment to democratic values.

■ STUDY LINK

IR → India-Southeast Asia → Neighbourhood First → Act East | Geography → Northeast India border states

HIGH

SC Quashes ISRO Gang Labour Scheme — State as Model Employer

GS-II
(Governance +
Judiciary +
Social Justice)
Indian Polity

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Supreme Court in *R. Iyyappan v. Union of India* (2026 INSC 431) quashed ISRO's Gang Labourers (Employment for Sporadic Types of Work) Scheme, 2012 at Mahendragiri unit (Tamil Nadu). Workers served 14-26 years. SC directed regularisation from September 9, 2010. Ruling: 'State as model employer cannot be indifferent to workforce who contributed to national endeavours.'

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

■ TIMELINE

The SC ruled that ISRO cannot use artificial 'sporadic work' categories to deny regularisation to workers performing permanent functions for 14-26 years. The 2012 Gang Labour Scheme was found to violate Article 14 (equality). ISRO Mahendragiri = Liquid Propulsion Systems Centre (LPSC), Tamil Nadu — tests liquid rocket engines.

ISRO founded August 15, 1969 by Dr. Vikram Sarabhai. Mahendragiri (LPSC) established 1971 in Tamil Nadu. The 2012 Scheme created daily-wage categories to avoid regularisation. SC applied the Umadevi (2006) exception — workers serving 10+ years on permanent posts are eligible for regularisation despite the general rule against automatic regularisation.

1969 (Aug 15) — ISRO founded; HQ Bengaluru

1971 — Mahendragiri (LPSC) established in Tamil Nadu

2006 — SC Umadevi judgment — restricts but allows exceptions for long-service contract workers

2012 — ISRO notifies Gang Labourers Scheme — daily-wage category

2026 — SC quashes 2012 Scheme; regularisation directed from Sep 9, 2010

■ KEY DATA

Legal Basis	Provision	Application to Case
Model Employer Doctrine	Article 14 + Article 21	State cannot arbitrarily deny equal treatment to workers
Right to Dignity	Article 21	14-26 year precarious employment = dignity violation
Right to Work (DPSP)	Article 41	State shall secure right to work in public employment
Living Wage (DPSP)	Article 43	State shall endeavour to secure living wage
CLRA 1970	Contract Labour (Regulation and Abolition) Act	Prohibits contract labour where work is of perennial nature
Umadevi (2006)	SC Precedent	Exception: regularisation for 10+ years on permanent posts

■ STATIC THEORY

- **MODEL EMPLOYER DOCTRINE:** State as a model employer has higher obligations than private employers; cannot use contractual categories for permanent functions; based on Articles 14 and 21
- **SECRETARY, STATE OF KARNATAKA v. UMADEVI (2006):** Landmark SC judgment — held automatic regularisation of all contract workers is NOT available; exception = 10+ years service on permanent posts without irregular appointment
- **CLRA 1970:** Contract Labour (Regulation and Abolition) Act prohibits contract labour where work is of perennial/permanent nature
- **ARTICLES 41+43 (DPSP):** Right to work and living wage — DPSPs used by SC to interpret fundamental rights in labour cases
- **ISRO MAHENDRAGIRI:** Liquid Propulsion Systems Centre (LPSC), Tamil Nadu — tests liquid rocket engines for ISRO missions including PSLV, GSLV, and Gaganyaan

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Case: R. Iyyappan v. Union of India — 2026 INSC 431

■ UPSC TRAPS

✗ ISRO Mahendragiri is in Karnataka

2. ISRO Mahendragiri = LPSC, Tamil Nadu (NOT Karnataka) 3. ISRO founded: August 15, 1969 (INCOSPAR = 1962, predecessor) 4. SC: 'State as model employer cannot be indifferent to workforce who contributed to national endeavours' 5. Workers: 14-26 years daily-wage service; regularisation from Sep 9, 2010 6. Constitutional basis: Art. 14 (equality) + Art. 21 (dignity) + DPSP Art. 41/43 7. Statutory basis: CLRA 1970 (perennial work cannot be contracted out)	✓ Mahendragiri (LPSC) is in Tamil Nadu ✗ ISRO was founded in 1962 ✓ ISRO founded August 15, 1969; INCOSPAR (predecessor) = 1962 ✗ Umadevi allows automatic regularisation of all contract workers ✓ Umadevi RESTRICTED auto-regularisation; exception only for 10+ years on permanent posts ✗ Model employer doctrine comes from a statute ✓ Derives from constitutional provisions — Articles 14 and 21
--	---

■ MAINS ANGLE

State's obligation as model employer — when PSUs use contractual labour for permanent functions, it violates constitutional equality and DPSP mandate; SC's role in enforcing labour rights against government employers.

■ STUDY LINK

Polity → Fundamental Rights Art.14/21 → DPSP Art. 41/43 | Governance → Labour Laws → CLRA 1970

HIGH

Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill 2026

GS-II (Social Justice + Polity)
Indian Polity

■ NEWS TRIGGER

Parliament passed the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill 2026 with more stringent penalties for offences. Opposition criticized exclusions — DM certificate requirement still contradicts NALSA 2014 self-identification direction; no reservation policy enacted despite NALSA direction.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The 2026 Amendment strengthens penal provisions of the 2019 Act (original max = 2 years, criticised as weak). Structural gaps remain: District Magistrate certificate for identity recognition (contradicts NALSA 2014); no reservations in education/employment; no recognition of same-sex relationships. Nodal ministry = Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment (MoSJE).

India's transgender rights evolved through judicial activism. NALSA v. Union of India (2014) recognised transgender as third gender and directed self-identification, reservations, and welfare. The 2019 Act fell short of NALSA's vision. The 2026 Amendment partially addresses penalties but leaves core contradictions with NALSA unresolved.

■ TIMELINE

2009 — Delhi HC decriminalises homosexuality (Naz Foundation v. NCT of Delhi)

2013 — SC overturns in Suresh Kumar Koushal — re-criminalises

2014 — NALSA v. Union of India — third gender recognised; self-ID + affirmative action directed

2017 — K.S. Puttaswamy v. UoI — Right to Privacy includes gender identity (Art. 21)

2018 — Navtej Singh Johar v. Uoi — Section 377 IPC decriminalised

2019 — Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act — DM certificate, NCTP, max 2 years penalty

2026 — Amendment Bill — stricter penalties; structural gaps remain

■ KEY DATA

Issue	NALSA 2014 Direction	2019 Act	2026 Amendment
Identity Recognition	Self-identification	DM certificate required	Unchanged
Reservations	Affirmative action directed	Not enacted	Not addressed
Penalties	Strong provisions needed	Max 2 years (weak)	STRENGTHENED
Definition	Inclusive	Narrow (critics say)	Unclear
Nodal Ministry	-	MoSJE	MoSJE

■ STATIC THEORY

- NALSA v. UNION OF INDIA (2014): SC recognised third gender; directed: self-identification, affirmative action/reservations in education+employment, welfare schemes, sensitisation
- NAVTEJ SINGH JOHAR v. UOI (2018): Section 377 IPC struck down — consensual same-sex acts decriminalised; violates Articles 14, 15, 19, 21
- K.S. PUTTASWAMY v. UOI (2017): Right to Privacy = fundamental right under Art. 21; includes gender identity and sexual orientation
- NCTP: National Council for Transgender Persons — under 2019 Act; chaired by Union Minister of MoSJE
- KEY TENSION: NALSA (2014) directed self-identification; 2019 Act imposed DM certificate = legislative regression from judicial direction; 2026 Amendment does not resolve this

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. NALSA (2014) = third gender recognised + self-ID + affirmative action directed
2. Navtej Singh Johar (2018) = Section 377 struck down
3. Puttaswamy (2017) = Right to Privacy includes gender identity
4. 2019 Act: DM certificate required (contradicts NALSA)
5. Nodal ministry = Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment (MoSJE)
6. NCTP = National Council for Transgender Persons
7. 2026 Amendment = stricter penalties; DM cert + no reservations remain

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ NALSA recognized same-sex marriage
- ✓ NALSA (2014) recognized THIRD GENDER; same-sex = Navtej Singh Johar (2018)
- ✗ Transgender Persons Act passed in 2020
- ✓ Act passed 2019; Rules notified 2020
- ✗ Ministry of Women and Child Development is nodal ministry
- ✓ Nodal ministry = Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment (MoSJE)
- ✗ 2019 Act follows NALSA self-identification direction
- ✓ 2019 Act CONTRADICTS NALSA — DM certificate required instead of self-identification

■ MAINS ANGLE

■ STUDY LINK

India's legal journey on transgender rights reflects tension between judicial progressivism (NALSA 2014) and legislative incrementalism — key gaps in reservation, self-identification, and social welfare remain unbridged by 2026 Amendment.

Polity → Fundamental Rights Art. 14/15/21 |
Social Justice → Marginalised Communities |
Landmark cases: NALSA → Puttaswamy →
Navtej Singh Johar → Transgender Act

HIGH

EAM Jaishankar Visits Bulgaria & Finland (June 10-11, 2026)

GS-II
(International
Relations)
International
Relations

NEWS TRIGGER

EAM S. Jaishankar is on a two-day visit to Bulgaria and Finland (June 10-11, 2026) per MEA. Finland joined NATO on April 4, 2023 as its 31st member — ending decades of Finlandisation. Sweden joined as 32nd member March 2024. India-EU FTA negotiations relaunched 2022.

INTRO & ORIGIN

EAM's visit to Bulgaria (EU 2007, NATO 2004) and Finland (EU 1995, NATO April 2023) signals India's deepening engagement with NATO's eastern and northern flanks. Finland's NATO accession — ending the Cold War Finlandisation doctrine — adds 1,340 km to NATO's Russia border. India navigates EU engagement while maintaining Russia ties (multi-alignment).

India-EU Strategic Partnership dates to 2004. India-EU FTA launched 2007, stalled 2013, relaunched 2022. India-EFTA Trade Agreement signed March 2024 (EFTA = Norway, Switzerland, Iceland, Liechtenstein — NOT EU). EFTA and EU are separate bodies — a common UPSC trap.

TIMELINE

- 2004 — India-EU Strategic Partnership; Bulgaria joins NATO
- 2007 — India-EU FTA negotiations launched; Bulgaria joins EU
- 2013 — India-EU FTA stalls
- 2022 — India-EU FTA relaunched; India-EU Connectivity Partnership (2021)
- Apr 4, 2023 — Finland joins NATO as 31st member — ends Finlandisation
- Mar 7, 2024 — Sweden joins NATO as 32nd member
- Mar 2024 — India-EFTA Trade Agreement signed (EFTA ≠ EU)
- Jun 10-11, 2026 — EAM Jaishankar visits Bulgaria + Finland

KEY DATA

Country	EU Membership	NATO Membership	Key India Relevance
Bulgaria	Since 2007	Since 2004	CEE gateway; historical NAM ties; Black Sea
Finland	Since 1995	Since Apr 4, 2023 (31st member)	Tech+innovation; 1,340 km Russia border; Arctic Council
Sweden	Since 1995	Since Mar 2024 (32nd member)	Nordic-India; defence industry
EFTA (4 countries)	NOT EU members	NOT NATO	India-EFTA Trade Deal signed Mar 2024

■ STATIC THEORY

- FINLANDISATION: Cold War doctrine of Finland maintaining neutrality to avoid Soviet hostility; joining NATO (April 2023) = end of Finlandisation; adds 1,340 km Russia-NATO border
- INDIA-EU STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP (2004): Trade ~115 billion euros/year; FTA negotiations relaunched 2022; India-EU Connectivity Partnership 2021 (rival to China BRI)
- INDIA-EFTA vs INDIA-EU FTA: EFTA = Norway, Switzerland, Iceland, Liechtenstein (4, non-EU); India-EFTA signed March 2024; India-EU FTA = different, still ongoing — most tested UPSC distinction
- NATO ARTICLE 5: Collective defence clause — attack on one = attack on all; Finland+Sweden accession strengthens eastern flank against Russia
- V4 (VISEGRÁD GROUP): Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Hungary — CEE bloc within EU; distinct voice on Russia + migration

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Finland joined NATO: April 4, 2023 (31st member) — ends Finlandisation
2. Sweden joined NATO: March 7, 2024 (32nd member) — Finland BEFORE Sweden
3. Finland shares ~1,340 km border with Russia
4. EFTA = Norway, Switzerland, Iceland, Liechtenstein (4 members, NOT EU)
5. India-EFTA Trade Deal signed March 2024 (NOT India-EU FTA)
6. India-EU FTA relaunched 2022 — still ongoing
7. Bulgaria: EU 2007, NATO 2004

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Finland has been in NATO since Cold War
- ✓ Finland joined NATO only April 4, 2023 (was non-aligned — Finlandisation)
- ✗ Sweden joined NATO before Finland
- ✓ Finland (April 2023, 31st) joined BEFORE Sweden (March 2024, 32nd)
- ✗ India-EFTA deal = India-EU FTA
- ✓ EFTA and EU are DIFFERENT; India-EFTA signed March 2024; India-EU FTA still ongoing
- ✗ Bulgaria joined EU in 2004
- ✓ Bulgaria joined EU in 2007; NATO in 2004 — different years

■ MAINS ANGLE

EAM visits to NATO's newest eastern/northern flank members reflect India's calibrated European diplomacy — deepening EU ties for FTA and technology while maintaining Russia engagement; multi-alignment tested by post-Ukraine European security realignment.

■ STUDY LINK

IR → India-Europe Relations → India-EU Strategic Partnership → NATO expansion | Geography → Nordic + Balkan regions

■ MEDIUM UPSC RELEVANCE

MEDIUM

PM Modi Visits France & Slovakia (June 13-18, 2026)

GS-II
(International
Relations)
International
Relations

■ NEWS TRIGGER

PM Modi scheduled to visit France and Slovakia on June 13-18, 2026 (MEA). France = India's oldest strategic partner (1998). Slovakia PM Robert Fico survived assassination attempt May 2024; holds EU's most pro-Russia stance — resonates with India's multi-alignment position.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

India-France ties = most comprehensive European strategic partnership: Rafale (IAF + Navy), Jaitapur NPP (Maharashtra, EDF, 6 EPR reactors, 9.6 GW), ISRO-CNES space cooperation, Horizon 2047 roadmap. France is also an Indo-Pacific power (Réunion, New Caledonia, French Polynesia, Mayotte). Slovakia's V4 membership and Fico's dialogue stance on Ukraine give it strategic significance for India.

India-France Strategic Partnership (1998) = India's FIRST strategic partnership with any country. The partnership has deepened through multiple Rafale deals, Jaitapur NPP negotiations, and the Horizon 2047 (2022) 25-year roadmap. Slovakia under Fico represents the V4 (Visegrád Group) bloc's voice and the most Russia-friendly stance in EU — aligning with India's own call for dialogue in Ukraine conflict.

■ TIMELINE

1998 — India-France Strategic Partnership — India's FIRST strategic partnership with any country

2016 — Rafale deal: 36 jets for IAF (Dassault Aviation)

2022 — Horizon 2047 roadmap announced (Modi-Macron)

May 2024 — Slovakia PM Robert Fico survives assassination attempt

2024 — Rafale Marine deal — Naval Rafale for Indian Navy carriers

Jun 13-18, 2026 — PM Modi visits France + Slovakia

■ KEY DATA

Element	Details	UPSC Relevance
Jaitapur NPP	Ratnagiri, Maharashtra; 6 EPR reactors; 9.6 GW; EDF (France)	Location + technology + partner = prelims trap
Rafale (IAF)	36 jets; 2016 deal; Dassault Aviation	Defence procurement
Rafale Marine	Naval version; 2024 deal; INS Vikrant/Vikramaditya	Navy modernisation
ISRO-CNES	India-France space cooperation	Gaganyaan support; satellite launches
Horizon 2047	25-year India-France strategic roadmap (2022)	GS-II Mains theme
France Indo-Pacific	Territories: Reunion, New Caledonia, French Polynesia, Mayotte	France = Indo-Pacific power — trap
V4 (Slovakia)	Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Hungary	CEE bloc within EU

■ STATIC THEORY

- **INDIA-FRANCE STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP (1998):** India's FIRST; covers defence, nuclear, space, digital, climate; elevated through Horizon 2047 (2022) 25-year cooperation roadmap
- **JAITAPUR NPP:** Ratnagiri district, Maharashtra; 6 EPR (Evolutionary Power Reactor) units; 9.6 GW = would be world's largest; partner = EDF (Electricite de France); pending final agreement
- **FRANCE AS INDO-PACIFIC POWER:** Overseas territories — Reunion (Indian Ocean), New Caledonia + French Polynesia (Pacific), Mayotte (Indian Ocean); French Navy patrols Indo-Pacific
- **V4 / VISEGRÁD GROUP:** Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Hungary; CEE bloc formed 1991; coordinates EU positions; Slovakia under Fico = most Russia-friendly V4 member

- HORIZON 2047: 25-year India-France strategic roadmap announced 2022; covers defence, space, nuclear, digital, climate, people-to-people

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. India-France Strategic Partnership = 1998 = India's FIRST strategic partnership
2. Jaitapur NPP: Ratnagiri, Maharashtra | EDF (France) | 6 EPR reactors | 9.6 GW
3. Rafale IAF: 2016 deal, 36 jets | Rafale Marine (Navy): 2024 deal
4. France Indo-Pacific territories: Reunion, New Caledonia, French Polynesia, Mayotte
5. V4 = Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Hungary (NOT Bulgaria/Romania)
6. Horizon 2047 = 25-year India-France roadmap (announced 2022)

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Jaitapur NPP is in Gujarat
- ✓ Jaitapur is in Ratnagiri district, MAHARASHTRA
- ✗ Jaitapur uses Russian VVER technology
- ✓ Jaitapur uses French EPR technology — partner = EDF
- ✗ France has no Indo-Pacific territory
- ✓ France has Reunion, New Caledonia, French Polynesia, Mayotte
- ✗ V4 includes Bulgaria or Romania
- ✓ V4 = ONLY Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Hungary

■ MAINS ANGLE

Modi's France-Slovakia visit reflects India's dual European strategy — deepening India-France flagship partnership (Horizon 2047) while engaging V4/CEE voices offering balanced Ukraine perspective; sustaining multi-alignment within EU itself.

■ STUDY LINK

IR → India-Europe → India-France Strategic Partnership → Nuclear Diplomacy → Indo-Pacific | Geography → Nuclear plants in India (Jaitapur location)

MEDIUM

PM Modi Speaks with Amir of Kuwait (June 9, 2026)

GS-II (IR +
Diaspora) +
GS-III (Economy)
International
Relations

■ NEWS TRIGGER

PM Modi's telephonic conversation with Kuwait's Amir Sheikh Meshal Al-Ahmad Al-Jaber Al-Sabah (June 9, 2026). Follows landmark December 2024 visit — first Indian PM visit to Kuwait in 43 years (last = Rajiv Gandhi 1990). India-Kuwait Strategic Partnership announced Dec 2024.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

Kuwait holds outsized importance for India: ~1 million Indians = Kuwait's largest expatriate community; significant remittances source; key oil supplier. GCC = 6 members (Saudi Arabia, UAE, Kuwait, Qatar, Bahrain, Oman). Kuwait's Amir Sheikh Meshal took office December 2023. Kuwaiti Dinar = world's highest valued currency.

■ TIMELINE

1961 (Jun 19) — Kuwait gains independence from Britain; India among first to recognise

India-Kuwait relations date to 1961 (Kuwait's independence). In 1990, Iraq invaded Kuwait — India evacuated ~170,000 Indians in one of history's largest peacetime evacuations. Modi's December 2024 visit ended a 34-year PM-level gap and established the Strategic Partnership framework. IMEC (India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor) announced at G20 2023 connects India through Gulf to Europe.

1981 — Kuwait = founding member of GCC (Gulf Cooperation Council)

1990 — Iraq invades Kuwait; India evacuates ~170,000 Indians; Rajiv Gandhi visits

Dec 2023 — Sheikh Meshal Al-Ahmad Al-Jaber Al-Sabah becomes Kuwait Amir

Dec 2024 — PM Modi visits Kuwait — first in 43 years; India-Kuwait Strategic Partnership; Modi gets Kuwait's highest civilian honor

Jun 9, 2026 — PM Modi telephonic call with Kuwait Amir

■ KEY DATA

Factor	Details	UPSC Angle
GCC Members	Saudi Arabia, UAE, Kuwait, Qatar, Bahrain, Oman (6 total)	Trap: exactly 6 members
Kuwaiti Dinar (KD)	World's highest valued currency; 1 KD approx Rs 270	Economy prelims trap
Indian Diaspora	~1 million Indians = Kuwait's largest expat community	Diaspora diplomacy
IMEC	India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (G20 2023)	Multi-modal; India to Gulf to Europe
Kuwait Independence	June 19, 1961 (from Britain)	Founding year — CA format requirement
Kuwait Investment Authority	KIA = Kuwait sovereign wealth fund (one of world's largest)	Potential FDI into India

■ STATIC THEORY

- GCC (GULF COOPERATION COUNCIL): Founded 1981; 6 members: Saudi Arabia, UAE, Kuwait, Qatar, Bahrain, Oman; HQ Riyadh; India-GCC FTA negotiations ongoing
- INDIA'S GULF DIASPORA: ~9 million Indians in Gulf = world's largest diaspora concentration in any region; ~55% of India's total remittances (~\$120 billion/year); strategic asset for Gulf diplomacy
- IMEC: India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor; announced G20 New Delhi 2023; multi-modal (ship+rail+road); India-UAE-Saudi-Jordan-Israel-Europe; alternative to China's BRI
- INDIA'S LINK WEST POLICY: Complements Act East; Gulf focus driven by energy security, diaspora, remittances, trade
- KUWAITI DINAR: KD = world's highest valued currency (1 KD = ~\$3.26 = ~Rs 270); Kuwait's wealth from oil (6th largest reserves globally)

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. GCC = 6 members: Saudi Arabia, UAE, Kuwait, Qatar, Bahrain, Oman (NOT 7)
2. Kuwait Amir: Sheikh Meshal Al-Ahmad Al-Jaber Al-Sabah (since Dec 2023)
3. Modi Dec 2024 = first Indian PM visit in 43 years (last = Rajiv Gandhi 1990)

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ GCC has 7 members
- ✓ GCC has exactly 6: Saudi Arabia, UAE, Kuwait, Qatar, Bahrain, Oman
- ✗ UAE Dirham = world's highest valued currency

4. ~1 million Indians in Kuwait = Kuwait's largest expat community 5. Kuwaiti Dinar = world's HIGHEST valued currency 6. IMEC = India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (G20 2023) 7. 1990 Kuwait evacuation = ~170,000 Indians (one of history's largest peacetime evacuations)	✓ Kuwaiti Dinar (KD) = world's highest valued currency ✗ Modi's Dec 2024 Kuwait visit = first ever Indian PM visit ✓ First visit in 43 YEARS — Rajiv Gandhi visited Kuwait in 1990 ✗ USA is largest Gulf remittance source to India ✓ USA is largest SINGLE-COUNTRY source; Gulf COMBINED = ~55% of India's total remittances
---	--

■ MAINS ANGLE

India's Gulf diplomacy under Link West strategy — energy security, diaspora welfare, remittances, IMEC connectivity, investment from sovereign wealth funds; Kuwait Strategic Partnership as template for GCC-wide engagement.

■ STUDY LINK

IR → India-Gulf Relations → GCC → IMEC → Energy Diplomacy | Economy → Remittances → Balance of Payments | Society → Indian Diaspora

MEDIUM

UPI-Nepal (NPI) Cross-Border Digital Payment Linkage

GS-II (IR + Governance) +
GS-III (Economy + S&T) Economy

■ NEWS TRIGGER

India's UPI (Unified Payments Interface) being linked with Nepal's NPI (Nepal Payment Interface), announced during Nepal FM Shisir Khanal's visit (June 2026). Will enable real-time cross-border digital payments — formalising massive informal flows given open border and ~7-8 million Nepali workers in India.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

UPI launched April 11, 2016 by NPCI (National Payments Corporation of India — not-for-profit, under RBI+IBA, NOT a statutory body). NPCI International Payments Limited (NIPL) handles global UPI expansion. Bhutan = first country to adopt UPI (2021). Singapore PayNow = first bilateral real-time link (February 2023). Nepal remittances = ~25% of Nepal's GDP.

NPCI incorporated 2008 as not-for-profit company under Companies Act (NOT under Payment and Settlement Systems Act — common trap). India's DPI (Digital Public Infrastructure) = UPI + Aadhaar + CoWIN, promoted as global model at G20 2023. India-Nepal open border (Treaty of Peace and Friendship 1950) makes UPI-NPI link significant for formalising informal cross-border cash flows.

■ TIMELINE

2008 — NPCI incorporated (not-for-profit, RBI+IBA guidance)

2016 (Apr 11) — UPI launched by NPCI

2021 — Bhutan adopts UPI QR — FIRST country to adopt UPI

Feb 2023 — India-Singapore UPI-PayNow link — FIRST bilateral real-time cross-border link

2023 — UPI in UAE, Sri Lanka, Malaysia, UK, France; G20: DPI promoted globally

Mar 2024 — UPI crosses 100 billion annual transactions

Jun 2026 — UPI-Nepal NPI bilateral link announced

■ KEY DATA

Country/System	Year	Link Type	Significance
Bhutan	2021	UPI QR adoption	First country to adopt UPI
Singapore (PayNow)	Feb 2023	Bilateral real-time link	First bilateral cross-border real-time payment
UAE, Sri Lanka, Malaysia, UK, France	2023	UPI acceptance	Expanding global footprint
Nepal (NPI)	2026	Bilateral real-time link	Open border + remittance formalisation

■ STATIC THEORY

- NPCI: National Payments Corporation of India — NOT-FOR-PROFIT company under Companies Act; set up under RBI + IBA guidance (2008); owns UPI, RuPay, IMPS, FASTag, NACH, BBPS
- UPI ARCHITECTURE: Built on IMPS; interoperable between banks; 24/7/365; uses Virtual Payment Address (VPA); regulated by RBI
- NIPL: NPCI International Payments Limited — subsidiary of NPCI for global UPI expansion; signs bilateral agreements with foreign payment systems
- DPI (DIGITAL PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE): India Stack = Aadhaar (identity) + UPI (payments) + CoWIN (health); promoted at G20 2023 as model for developing nations
- INDIA-NEPAL: Treaty of Peace and Friendship 1950 = open border; ~7-8 million Nepali workers in India; Nepal Rupee pegged to Indian Rupee (1 INR = 1.6 NPR); remittances = ~25% of Nepal GDP

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. UPI launched: April 11, 2016 (NOT 2014 or 2015)
2. NPCI = not-for-profit under Companies Act (NOT statutory body under PSS Act 2007)
3. Bhutan = FIRST country to adopt UPI (2021)
4. Singapore PayNow = FIRST bilateral real-time cross-border link (February 2023)
5. NIPL = NPCI International Payments Limited
6. Nepal Rupee pegged to Indian Rupee: 1 INR = 1.6 NPR
7. India-Nepal Treaty of Peace and Friendship: 1950

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Bhutan = first bilateral UPI link
- ✓ Bhutan adopted UPI QR (2021) but Singapore PayNow = first BILATERAL REAL-TIME link (Feb 2023)
- ✗ NPCI is statutory body under Payment and Settlement Systems Act 2007
- ✓ NPCI is NOT-FOR-PROFIT COMPANY under Companies Act — not a statutory body
- ✗ UPI launched in 2014 under Jan Dhan Yojana
- ✓ UPI launched April 11, 2016; Jan Dhan = 2014 (different)
- ✗ Nepal Rupee is not linked to Indian Rupee
- ✓ Nepal Rupee PEGGED to Indian Rupee: 1 INR = 1.6 NPR (fixed rate)

■ MAINS ANGLE

India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) as instrument of Neighbourhood First diplomacy — UPI-Nepal link formalises informal cross-border economies; India's DPI export as soft power and development cooperation model.

■ STUDY LINK

Economy → Payment Systems → NPCI → Digital India → Financial Inclusion | IR → India-Nepal Relations → Neighbourhood First | S&T → Digital Public Infrastructure